

The Musical Achievement

The first thing to do when considering the musical achievement of jazz is to forget that of classical Western music. The two are non-competitive, in spite of the efforts of stubborn adversaries of jazz among the classicists, and of some jazz and classical modernists, to establish that they are not. If we ask: has jazz produced anything like the Beethoven Ninth, or the Bach *B Minor Mass*, or *Don Giovanni*, the answer must be a flat no. Nor is it likely to produce music to compete with the Western classical art tradition, except conceivably in the field of opera. If we judge jazz by the standards of Western art-music, we can say that it has produced a number of beautiful melodies—but no more beautiful ones than Western art, or even light and pop music,^{*} a particularly successful genre of accompanied *lieder*, in the vocal blues, a few suites of the late romantic type, a great variety of formally uncontrolled, but imaginatively most fertile ‘variations on a theme’, and a few exercises in such forms as fugues and canons. The achievement is a minor one, in terms of absolute and architectural music.

If we judge jazz playing by the standards of Western art-playing, the balance-sheet is more impressive, for not even the most stubborn classicist will deny that jazz has vastly extended the range and technical possibilities of every instrument it has touched, with the exception of the smaller stringed ones; and few will even deny that, man for man, the finest jazz players are—perhaps with the exception of the pianists—considerably superior to their classical opposite numbers. But we are, after all, here considering jazz not as a pioneer of novel instrumental combinations and colours and new instrumental possibilities, but as a music with self-contained achievements.

It has achievements but not in terms of art-music, the very concepts of which are alien to it. This does not mean that jazz may not influence art-

music, or fuse with it. Indeed it has shown a marked tendency to do so of late. But when it does it will no longer be jazz, but jazz-based art-music, just as Bizet's *Carmen*, and even de Falla, are not Spanish popular music, but Spanish or Spanish-tinged art-music. Jazz already has its Bizet: George Gershwin's *Porgy and Bess*, the finest American contribution to opera so far, bears the same sort of relation to jazz as *Carmen* does to Spanish music; indeed, a rather closer relation, since a diluted form of jazz belonged to Gershwin's musical idiom.[‡] It has not yet developed its de Falla, or more exactly, its Bartók or Mussorgsky, but there is no *a priori* musical reason why one day it should not.

The fundamental unit of the orthodox arts is the 'work of art' which, once created, lives its life independently of all but its creator; sometimes, as when critics object to a Yeats or Auden revising their own verses, even of him. If it is a picture, it has merely to be preserved; if a book, to be produced. Music and drama have to be performed, but in our academic generation this has increasingly come to mean 'interpreted as nearly as possible in the way intended by its original producer'. Virtually all historic-musical scholarship is no more than an attempt to recapture this original, authoritative authenticity: there are men who regret that we cannot hear our Handel exactly as Handel meant us to because, unfortunately, we no longer castrate boy singers. The 'work of art' which is particularly appreciated we call a masterpiece, a category wholly independent of performance. No one thinks less of Figaro because the Lesser Wigston amateur operatic society murders him.

Now jazz simply does not function this way. Its art is not reproduced, but created, and exists only at the moment of creation. The nearest orthodox parallel is in those arts which have never been quite able to get rid of their popular, not to say vulgar, origins: on the stage. For actors, and indeed for most of us part of the time, drama is what the actors and other stage people make it. A play, however poetic, which is not at the same time a 'vehicle'—i.e. which does not allow actors to act—is dead. A great drama abominably acted is merely potential drama. A Henry Irving, who probably never in his life acted in a good unspoiled play, produced a greater emotional catharsis more often than Mr X who has never acted except in the most authentically produced Shakespeare,

because Irving was a greater artist. When it comes to music-hall artists, we admit this freely: a Chaplin or a Marie Lloyd produce great art, even when their subject-matter is, by orthodox standards, minor art or no art at all.

This is the way jazz works—though its supreme contribution to the popular arts is a combination of individualism and collective creation, which has long been forgotten in our orthodox culture. It happens that, thanks to the gramophone, bits and pieces of that continuous process of joint creation which is the life of the jazz musician in employment are separated out as ‘works’, even as ‘masterpieces’. But they are not finished works, even if they are ‘composed’ or ‘arranged’. A Louis Armstrong may say to himself on hearing a play-back of his 1928 *West End Blues*: ‘That’s a good version, I’ll stick to it whenever I play this piece in future at three-minute length’, and a Duke Ellington or John Lewis may say of a recording: ‘That is about how it ought to sound.’ But if we could hear every *West End Blues*, *Across the Track*, or *Django* ever played, even by Armstrong, the Ellington band, and the Modern Jazz Quartet themselves, we should hear an unending series of re-creations and modifications, a life-long flux. Moreover, the individual piece is not, for the jazz musician or the jazz-lover, the real unit of the art. If there is a natural unit of jazz, it is the ‘session’—the evening or night in which one piece after another is played—fast and slow, formal and informal, the whole gamut of emotions. Continuous creation is the essence of this music, and the fact that most of it is fugitive troubles the musician no more than the ballet dancer.

If there is no authenticity and no permanence in the sense of our orthodox arts, neither is there the sharp distinction between the genius and the rest. It is not the object of jazz to produce works, or even performances, which can be classed in a special category of critical excellence, but to enjoy the music, and to make others enjoy it, while creating it. There are, of course, geniuses: Armstrong, Bessie Smith, or Charlie Parker for example. But the essentially collective and practically-minded character of the music means that the value of the music, even of a particular piece, is largely independent of them, so long as there is a sufficiently large body of professional craftsmen of adequate competence and creativity. Nobody can draw up a list of the twenty best recorded

instrumental blues. After one or two obvious choices, there are hundreds of records (and in real life, thousands of performances) which would be, in their way, equally good. Good jazz, like a good cook or couturier, is not judged by producing works which, even in memory, stand out as the best ever, but by the capacity to produce constant variety at a high level of excellence. Jazz, in fact, is ‘music for use’, to use Hindemith’s phrase, not museum music or music for ranking by examiners.

None of this means that jazz is minor art in the way in which light and pop music is; merely that it gets its effects as major art in a different, and formally more economical, way from art-music. Stephen Foster’s or George Gershwin’s songs are pretty and enjoyable, but nobody would expect to get the emotion out of them that we draw from Schubert’s *Erlkönig* or *In diesen heil’gen Hallen*. But from Bessie Smith’s *Young Woman’s Blues* we can draw this emotion. Kreisler playing *Caprice Viennois* merely shows off a dazzling technique in a pleasant tune; but Louis Armstrong playing *It’s Tight Like This* takes us into the emotional realms of Macbeth’s soliloquies. Even Johann Strauss’s *Emperor Waltz*, perhaps as high-grade a piece of light classical music as has been composed, merely gives us a great deal of pleasure and satisfaction, but it is well worth swapping it, even as recorded by the Vienna Philharmonic, for *Parker’s Mood*. Admittedly the relatively small scale on which jazz operates as art limits its scope: after all, a single speech of *Phèdre* is quite within the compass of jazz whereas the whole tragedy is not. But what there is of jazz at its best is heavy stuff: it is small, but made of uranium.

The pleasures of jazz are therefore first and foremost in the emotion it generates, which cannot be isolated from the actual music. This may be illustrated by the persistent prejudice of everybody connected with the music—players, critics, and fans—in favour of improvisation. There is no special musical merit in improvisation, which is merely spur-of-the-moment composition, and therefore likely to be less good than considered and revised composition.[±] For the listener it is musically irrelevant that what he hears is improvised or written down. If he did not know he could generally not tell the difference. But improvisation, or at least a margin of it around even the most ‘written’ jazz compositions, is rightly cherished, because it stands for the constant living re-creation of

the music, the excitement and inspiration of the players which is communicated to us. There is very little doubt that the most powerful effects of jazz lie in the intensified communication of human emotion. That is why the primitive sung blues has retained its unchallenged place in it, and why the technically imperfect and primitive discs of New Orleans jazz hold their own, so long as they 'blow out', while the orchestrations and compositions often date. This is true even of modern jazz, in spite of the claims of some of its supporters. What survives in Parker, and has conquered even many of those who were originally most repelled by his innovations, is its 'tortured, searing, blasting beauty, reminiscent of the shouting gospel congregations of the South'.¹ His innovations belong to history, and if there had been nothing more to him than this he would be no more important than W. C. Handy, who first wrote down the blues.

Jazz is thus players' music and music directly expressing emotions, and its technical forms of creation and musical possibilities reflect both facts. For instance, it does not depend on a 'composer'—for we can hardly call the collection of simple themes which make up the general jazz repertoire (the so-called 'standards') compositions. They may be good tunes or bad, folk blues or pop ballads, or some other themes, but their merit is irrelevant. If their harmonies lend themselves to jazz development, they will do. The blues always do, and fortunately they are good music, but the only lasting merit of *All the Things You Are* or *How High the Moon*, which have become 'modern' standards, or *I Can't Give You Anything but Love, Baby* and the other standards of the 1920s is that they are good pegs on which to hang jazz. The original jazz 'composition'—i.e. performance—emerged simply from the interplay of various musicians on a given theme, according to certain rough rules of convenience or tradition. A 'new' composition could come into being in three ways: by playing a different theme, by getting together a different group of players—provided always they knew one another well enough to cooperate smoothly—and by playing the same theme with the same musicians another time, when one or more of the players had different ideas. The result was a mass of varied 'compositions' of the same scope and in the same idiom. It is obvious that accident plays a great part in

such musical creation which is, in a sense, like good talk or a good football match, in which anything—the combination of a particular group of people, the presence of one particularly stimulating person, a good audience, or just one of those good moods—can make all the difference. (The old-established tendency for some players to take drink or marihuana, or some other drug, is merely an attempt to eliminate this fortuitousness by artificially establishing the ‘good mood’ in which the musician creates freely. How far it does so is a matter for debate.)

This accidental factor remains strong, even when jazz composition becomes somewhat more systematic with the ‘arrangement’. The most intelligent jazz composers have always recognized that jazz is not composed with notes or instruments but with creative men and women. As M. Hodeir, the best of the classically trained critics has put it, in jazz the ‘fusion of individualities’ takes ‘the place of architecture’. The good jazz composer-arranger either imagines his sound and then looks for particular individual players whose personal voice comes nearest to his ideas, or derives his ideas from the personalities of his actual team. The greatest of the Creole composers, Jelly-Roll Morton, seems to have chosen the first course, a relatively easy matter in so unified a style of playing as that of New Orleans. The young Duke Ellington generally leaned more towards the second: we can actually observe him ‘discovering’ the ‘growl’ sound of his brass from Charley Ivris (trombone) and the late Bubber Miley (trumpet), and later building some of his most characteristic orchestral effects on it. In his earlier works the ‘composition’ is often little more than the assembling and shaping of the ideas spontaneously produced by the players. This is why the successful jazz composer has almost invariably been a band-leader, or at least permanently attached to a band; and why the most elaborate jazz compositions (for instance Ellington’s) have rarely been taken up—except as straight imitations—elsewhere. As soon as they are played by other players they change. Conversely, the composer himself is limited by having to find musicians who have his house style, or else he is obliged to modify his own style. Thus Ellington has been visibly troubled by the loss of Barney Bigard in 1942, for his liquid creole clarinet had become part of his musical palette, and subsequent replacements have not been wholly successful. Of course capable musicians entering a band

with a marked house style of its own can very often adapt themselves to it. Jazz composition has only slowly emancipated itself from this dependence on the individual personalities of its players. Perhaps this is a major reason why so far no full-scale jazz composition, e.g. a jazz opera, has emerged. Gershwin, who has brought off the nearest thing to it in *Porgy and Bess*, was used to working in the orthodox tradition, i.e. to writing in terms of notes on paper and not of specific men. Ellington, whose idea of a ‘concerto’—and a highly successful one too, as witness the marvellous *Concerto for Cootie*²—was to write a piece bringing out the special qualities of each of his soloists, has undoubtedly found the step to impersonal composition hard to make.

If jazz composition is limited technically by the need to compose men rather than notes, it is equally limited by the nature of jazz creation, as we have sketched it above. To put it in a word, it stands or falls by the human emotions it generates, and not by its qualities as ‘pure’ music. It is, to quote the sagacious M. Hodeir again, ‘precisely the kind of music that can be listened to without burying one’s forehead in one’s hands ... in jazz “sensorial interests” greatly outweigh “intellectual passion” ... a sharpened sensuality takes the place of loftiness, and the fusion of individualities takes the place of architecture.’ The most intelligent jazz composers have instinctively recognized these limitations. Jelly-Roll Morton gave New Orleans music deliberate shape and elegance, but did not attempt to change it. Duke Ellington is almost exclusively a composer of pieces expressing moods, or re-creating sense-impressions, as the titles of his records indicate: *Mood Indigo*, *Misty Mornin’*, *Creole Love-Call*, *A Portrait of Bert Williams*, *Such Sweet Thunder*. Modern jazz composers have found their most fruitful field in incidental music to films, in which the jazz gift for mood-expression and music-painting is used to great effect, as in Chico Hamilton’s music for *Sweet Smell of Success* and John Lewis’s for *Sait-on jamais?* And why not? It is a long time, even in the classical arts, since anyone has objected to Hugo Wolf because he illustrates poems in song, or to Bizet, because a concert selection of *Carmen* does not sound so well as a Beethoven Quartet, or to Prokofiev’s *Cinderella*, because it is intended to go with a ballet. There is plenty of precedent for serious music which buttresses its own

architectural weaknesses by leaning on other arts, and strengthens these in turn. In the composite work of art—the ballet, the opera, the film—there is wide scope for jazz, and indeed this seems the most natural way of further development for a music which emerges from the popular arts, whose more elaborate achievements have always been in the nature of ‘mixed’ entertainments—‘variety’ at the lowest level, the composite pantomime-allegory-ballet-opera at its highest.

Jazz certainly possesses a ‘natural’ bent towards ‘pure’ music, but even this must not be confused with the tendencies of art-music. It emerges from the ordinary player’s pride in his technical expertise, which makes good players vie with one another to play increasingly ‘difficult’ things. Modern jazz is largely the product of such technical experimenting. Technical, but not architectural. Left to themselves, jazz players or composers formed in jazz will experiment with everything except musical forms. If they play fugues or canons it is because they are trying to imitate classical music. Anyone anxious to tell the difference between a ‘pure’ jazz composition and a jazz composition borrowing from classical music should compare, say, *Brilliant Corners* by Thelonious Monk with, say, John Lewis’s *Concorde*. In the first we will find experiments in tempo, and in the combined sound of saxophones, such as vibrato explosions in unison. In the second we shall find an orthodox, relatively simple, fugue. Not that architecture is lacking in such ‘pure’ jazz compositions; but, as might be expected in a players’ music, it is the architecture of the instrumental solo.

This is not a criticism of the increasingly numerous attempts to marry jazz and classical music. In the first place, there is no law against it. In the second place it is a perfectly reasonable thing, both for classical composers and for jazz musicians with ambition for more complex things, to break through the technical limitations of jazz. After all, it may be plausibly held that a genuine American classical music will emerge only when American composers have assimilated the idiom of their native folk-music (i.e. of jazz) as Spanish, Hungarian, Russian, Czech, Finnish, and English composers have in their own time assimilated theirs. In the third place, it is no doubt a good thing for the self-respect of jazz musicians (especially of black ones) that their music should prove its ability to satisfy even the intellectually more ambitious listener. I merely

wish to establish the important distinction between the sort of jazz which evolves toward more elaborate and 'legitimate' music in its own way, and the sort which results from the crossing of jazz and 'straight' music: the distinction between Jelly-Roll Morton's *Deep Creek Blues* and Paul Whiteman's 'symphonic jazz' in the 1920s, or between Thelonious Monk and Dave Brubeck in the 1950s. So far, of these two types of jazz, the first has produced better and more fruitful results than the second, though it is quite conceivable that this might one day cease to be the case.

What then, are the musical achievements of jazz? Its major, perhaps its only real achievement, is that it exists: a music which has rescued the qualities of folk-music in a world which is designed to extirpate them; and which has so far maintained them against the dual blandishments of pop music and art-music. Taken in isolation, no recorded version of the blues *How Long* is a great work of art, in the serious sense, though many of them are extremely moving, and though the tune is beautiful and the poetry good.

*How long, long, has that evening train been gone
How long, how long, baby how long?*

*I've got a girl who lives upon the hill
If she don't love me, I know who will
How long, how long, how long?*

*If I could holler like a mountain jack
Go up on the mountain and call my baby back,
How long, how long, how long.*

The important and artistically valid thing is that this theme should produce works as different as Count Basie's orchestral-cum-vocal version, the late Jimmy Yancey's beautiful piano solo, or Joe Turner's shouting blues,³ and that it should remain alive, and capable of stimulating every group of players who touch it to produce their own music: some good, some mediocre, some poor, but, given a certain competence and feeling, all of it genuinely touching the genuine music.

Whatever other and higher merits it has or may acquire, its chief merit is that of proving that genuine music, even in the twentieth century, can avoid both the blind-alleys of commercial pop music, which establishes its *rapport* with the public at the expense of art, and *avant-garde* art-music, which develops its art at the expense of cutting itself off from all but a chosen public of experts.

It has produced a great deal more, as M. Hodeir has demonstrated for the rare readers who possess both a good knowledge of jazz and of orthodox music, in his excellent book. (Note especially the chapters on The Romantic Imagination of Dickie Wells, Concerto for Cootie, Charlie Parker and The Problem of Improvisation.) There are artists of superb calibre and overpowering genius, works of permanent value, which may be played with equal or greater enjoyment thirty years after their original performance, and a crop of technical innovations of which orthodox music has so far made practically no use, perhaps because of the deficiencies of both its composers and its players. However, the very attempt to express the achievements of jazz in terms of art-music must, as I have already suggested, distort the nature of that achievement.

Admittedly, all this is small-scale work. Jazz is little music and not big music, in the same sense as lyrics are little poetry and epics big poetry; pottery little art and cathedrals big art. Limitation of scope and relative smallness of scale do not make an art less good or true or beautiful. They do, however, put certain artistic achievements out of its reach: a sports car is not a worse vehicle than an aeroplane, but one designed for different purposes. Jazz has many merits, and a large number of people have derived from it consistent and intense and self-respecting pleasure, and have been profoundly, and justifiably, moved by it. But there are things which jazz cannot do (as conversely, there are things which modern classical music cannot do), and no purpose is served by pretending otherwise, except to butter up the self-esteem of people who are too lazy or ignorant to understand the more complex forms of art. Jazz, like Keats's definition of poetry, is 'simple, sensuous, and passionate', though, unlike Keats's definition, it can also be technically highly sophisticated and demanding, while the apparent simplicity of its emotions often conceals very great complexity. Of

course, so do apparently simple emotions in real life. But there are other things in life and the arts than these, and jazz does not supply them.

Nevertheless, its place in the musical not to mention the general cultural history of our century is already assured. It has demonstrated the vitality, and the possibilities of evolution, of a people's music; and if ever a way is to be found out of the impasse into which the orthodox arts have penetrated in our age, it may well be found by studying the nature of jazz, its creators, and its public. (This no more implies that the orthodox arts are to be saved by imitating jazz than the study of the aerodynamics of birds means that planes have to be constructed to look like seagulls.) It has been increasingly unavoidable. However little orthodox musicians have done with it, they have not escaped its presence. And it has been pretty certainly the most important musical achievement of the United States of America to date; and quite certainly the only one to win international acceptance. No orthodox American composer is a genuinely international figure, as the great classical composers were in their day; all are provincial figures blown up by local pride, and perhaps enjoying a limited appreciation or a *succès d'estime* among the musically better-informed international public. But Louis Armstrong, Bessie Smith, Charlie Parker are accepted without question all over the world, wherever there is a public for jazz, and indeed wherever American culture is discussed; and so is jazz itself.

Notes

[1.](#) Stearns, 228.

[2.](#) Cf. also *Echoes of Harlem*—for Williams—and *Clarinet Lament*—for Bigard.

[3.](#) On Philips BBL 7190 (American), Atlantic LP 134, and London LTZ-K 15053 respectively.

[*](#) Let us not be superior about light and pop music. Utterly feeble in every other way, it has at its best, and even at its top-level average produced numerous splendid melodies, as witness Stephen Foster, George Gershwin and others. That some of us prefer other melodies is another matter.

[†](#) Thus the melody of *Summertime* is a literal, and doubtless unintentional, copy of the well-known spiritual *Sometimes I Feel Like a Motherless Child*.

[‡](#) Of course the jazz composer—i.e. every creative player—does consider and revise, but in the process of playing his parts over and over again, and, as it were, working them slowly into their finished form; that is, assuming he does not change his ideas and want to turn an elaborated piece into something else.